

**Medford Public Schools
Medford School Committee
Committee of the Whole
Vocational Education
April 24, 2013
7:00 p.m.
Superintendent's Conference Room
Medford High School**

The meeting was called to order by Vice Chairperson John Falco at 7:00 p.m. The following members were present: Ann Marie Cugno, Erin DiBenedetto, John Falco, George Scarpelli, Robert E. Skerry Jr., and Paulette Van der Kloot. Also present: Superintendent Roy E. Belson, Deputy Superintendent Beverly Nelson, Director of Administration and Finance Ann Giombetti, Vocational Director William C. Mahoney, Headmaster John Perella, Cambridge Vocational Director Michael Ananis and Somerville Director Leo DiSimone.

All rose to salute the Flag.

Chairperson Falco stated that the purpose of the meeting was to continue our review of the Medford Vocational program and explore options and models that might be adaptable to Medford.

Mr. Falco then asked the Superintendent for an update on vocational matters and to introduce the evening's agenda.

The Superintendent informed the Committee that the search for a new Director was underway.

He then distributed materials regarding Minuteman that were in the news and being discussed by their Regional Task force. Minuteman continues to struggle with in district/regional enrollment. The school needs non-member tuitions to stay viable. They are actively recruiting. A recent state audit showed that Minuteman violated bidding laws when it awarded a \$71,500 marketing contract to an outside firm to boost enrollment. Further, Minuteman's facility is in dire need of renovation. It is unlikely that member communities will support a major plan. Their Regional Task Force is struggling to find answers and some communities are looking to exit the regional district.

In the meantime we are projecting that an extra five-seven students could attend Minuteman next year at an additional cost of \$150,000. The state may help us lower that amount by reducing the actual tuition level to Minuteman.

The Superintendent stressed that any major changes to our vocational program were a year away since structural adjustments would take time to implement. However, it would be possible to introduce smaller adjustments for next year if the Committee approved.

The Superintendent responded to inquiries about the current Assistant Director's status by saying that she is doing a good job and he would rely on the incoming Director's assessment for guidance. Mr. Mahoney agreed.

The meeting continued with a presentation by Leo DiSimone who oversees the Somerville program. Somerville has 560 students enrolled in 14 vocational programs. The Somerville model is a "Comprehensive High School" approach which does not use the A and B week schedule. No Somerville students are in a formal co-op program. The rotating daily schedule hurts that option.

Students in Somerville can take upper level courses from the high school program. Somerville programs like auto body do not work with this model. Somerville uses competency criteria rather than seat time to determine vocational course completion. Somerville uses an exploratory program for ninth graders that allows for six days in each program of intent. Two-year programs are not sufficient for preparation in most trade/technical areas.

Cambridge Executive Director Mike Ananis distributed substantial information on the Cambridge model. Cambridge uses a "Block" schedule. 40% of Cambridge students are involved in some vocational programming. The Cambridge days have a solid co-op option for participating students.

The Cambridge schedule uses 80-minute blocks rather than the traditional 55-minute periods. He pointed out that a change to block scheduling would require collective bargaining.

PE in Cambridge is embedded into other programs. There are conflicts with singleton offerings. Cambridge also relies upon "competency" rather than seat time. Cambridge has an electronic method to track competency attainment. This allows students to accelerate their learning and open up the selection of electives.

Superintendent Belson pointed out that whatever model/hybrid that Medford adopts/adapts there are "trade-offs". He felt that the School Committee wanted to ensure that students would have access to more high school courses and that high school students could access more of the vocational programs. Vocational Director Mahoney stated that despite funding limitations, his program did allow for interaction with the high school. He felt that this could be resolved with the current A+B week schedule intact.

After substantial discussion School committee members asked that the following issues be explained and options developed:

- A summer exploratory program for vocational education

- After school program for vocational programs
- More opportunities for vocational students to take advanced high school courses
- More opportunities for high school students to explore vocational components.
- New Chapter 74 vocational programs like bio-tech, robotics, and environmental science.
- More outreach to middle school students

Members thanked our guests from Somerville and Cambridge for sharing their ideas.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry, seconded by Mr. Scarpelli the meeting was adjourned at 9:20 p.m.

Respectfully Submitted,

John Falco
Vice Chairperson